



Assignment:1

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Section : 03

CST301 : For the Love of Food

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Recipe as Archive

It is happiness that we experience with every bite of food. It does not merely fill our stomachs, it reminds us who we are, where we belong as well as what we love. Food is accompanied by the stories of the hearth, parents and love as the simplest form of care. A generational recipe is not merely a catalogue of ingredients, it contains something personal and eternal. Such as, the domestic kitchen, the grandma's table and laughing with each other. Recipes are breathing memories which preserve not only tastes, but also voices, love and warm moments with the loved. We feel them again whenever we make these dishes by remembering them. When we consume these homemade meals, we bestow a gift which cannot be brought back by time.

Authenticity, Identity and Migration

The people of Khulna are generally fond of spicy dishes, and one of the most traditional preparations is Beef Curry with Chui Jhal, a dish valued for its authentic connection to this region. The incomparable ingredient is Chui Jhal, a peppery root stem of the Piper chaba plant that turns simple beef into a dish embodying regional identity and its entrenched in Khulna's food culture as both spice and important flavor profile, distinguishing this area's cuisine from other regions in Bangladesh (Heritage Info, 2024).

Over years, family recipes of choosing, preparing and cooking Chui Jhal have been taught through observation and practice, with older women in Khulna teaching younger female family members during festivals. This transmission does not occur via written recipes but through hands working upon hands, by tasting and adjusting, by the embodied experience of feeling stem tenderness and intuition in dividing the fine moment to pour spice into the pot. These forms demonstrate cultural continuity and also indicate that migration has disrupted traditional practices, since younger ones growing up outside Khulna never learn the embodied skills. The spice is consumed fresh, its tender stems peeled and added at certain points during cooking, which locals believe is key to acquiring traditional flavor.

Traditional Bengali medicine also regards Chui Jhal highly. It improves food digestion by increasing digestive enzymes and preventing bloating, may reduce arthritis and muscle pain, is warming, helps the body fight infections, runs mucus, and has strong antioxidants and antimicrobial agents (Heritage Info, 2024). Piper chaba H. belonging to the Piperaceae family is a famous example of traditional medicinal plants containing bioactive phytochemicals, used as antidiarrheal, antimicrobial, analgesic, antioxidant, anticancer and cytotoxic agents; locally known as Chuijhal, the stem is used as spice (Parvin et al., 2024). This makes Chui Jhal both a healer and a preserver of tradition.

One of the famous recipes of Eid-ul-Adha is Beef Curry with Chui Jhal that is placed in the centre stage every year and is a combination of religion, tradition and flavor. This began as a local

delicacy but it has spread to the rest of Bangladesh, bringing the taste of home back to Khulna and Satkhira. Individuals are becoming accustomed to the spice and its exclusive flavor because Chui Jhal is currently available in shops around the nation and on the menus of restaurants, introducing Khulna flavor to the masses (Heritage Info, 2024). Famous restaurants like Abbas Hotel in Chuknagar, Kamrul at Zero-point, and also one in Patkelghata, Satkhira have built their reputations on authentic Chui Jhal curry, carrying the true taste of the region. This indicates a strong desire to taste food of a specific location, preserve memory by flavor, and share local traditions with the broader community.

The use of authority on authenticity changes according to circumstances. In Bangladesh, family members remaining in Khulna, particularly women who cook fresh Chui Jhal during festivals are regarded as bearers of authenticity. They base their power on ongoing practice, proximity to conventional knowledge sources, and knowledge built throughout decades. But as these dishes are replicated by newer generations or migrated families, new adaptations have their own rights to authority by balancing tradition and pragmatic pressure. Authenticity is no longer about strict compliance but pursuing essence and changing to fit the situation. This bargaining indicates larger arguments between conservation and accommodation, respecting history and the present moment.

Ingredients and Preservation by the Ancestors

When preparing Beef Curry with Chui Jhal, our family tradition demands using fresh Chui Jhal produced in Khulna, which is incomparable. It adds distinct peppery spiciness and aroma that make this meal. However, there are ingredients that can be substituted like onion, ginger and garlic, and even the kind of beef used may vary with availability. We prefer local Chui Jhal because it cannot be replicated in taste. Preserved ones can offer a fresh bite. To preserve Chui Jhal for a long time, fresh stems are cleaned and peeled, cut into 2-3 cm pieces, air-dried in shade or sun, then stored in an airtight container away from moisture in a cool, dry place preferably below 25°C, which maintains peak taste and potency for 6-12 months. It is a way of not losing our home, of having a bit of home in every mouth. Certain local ingredients are given priority as they preserve the original flavor, sense of culture and localness, and have natural health advantages like garlic, ginger, turmeric powder.

Taste and strength of Chui Jhal depend on the kind and section of stem used. Fresh young stems are very pungent in odor, requiring slicing into very thin pieces and slight frying to open up their pungency; old and woody stems need long cooking to be softened and infused with curry. The local Khulna type is what my family chooses because the levels of heat and fragrance are most balanced to ensure our food has classic flavor and smell. The stems in Khulna region have characteristic pungency due to alluvial soil and wet climate, which Chui Jhal from other regions lacks.

I remember during Eid season, my grandmother cut fresh chui jhal in chunks about 2-3 cm long, a bit narrow, and placed it in beef curry. The odor in the kitchen was so unfamiliar to anything we

had encountered sharp and vivid. It was a breakthrough as we knew that not only could it preserve the spice, but it also added flavor, and thus this component became the center of our parties. From then on, we have always cut and cooked the stems very carefully in all our recipes with the object of preservation as well as improving flavor.

Migration, Labor and Ritual Persistence

Migration changed the way my family makes Beef Curry with Chui Jhal in essence. We shifted to Dhaka in the early 2000s and my mother did not get the fresh Chui Jhal she had been taking her whole life. The morning of Eid in Khulna, my grandma would rise early, with knowing hands pick fresh stems, and my mother spent hours with her learning to peel them carefully. It was labor transmitted mother to daughter, an unheard heritage. However, in Dhaka, my mother started having dried Chui Jhal packets sent by our family back home. Each package represented a small surrender. Dried Chui Jhal needed less preparation and could be stored for a long time. The trend persisted even in urban life and I never managed fresh Chui Jhal. People say city rhythms have replaced home traditions, but in our case, we continued relying on packaged chui jhal from Khulna that is surrounded with love.

Yet certain rituals endure. It is served during Eid-ul-Adha and Eid-ul-Fitr days, freshly cut beef is served and during family weddings Beef Curry with Chui Jhal is the menu of the day, no wedding is complete without this preparation. The order of serving remains ritualistic. My grandfather is served the first plate, with soft murmur praying, then grandmother, my father, my mother and lastly we children. I once went too far, and my mom just grabbed my hand: "Wait, my child. Not yet." My grandmother looked at me with silent pained eyes when I suggested we should have dinner together. The items may now arrive in packages but what we still have is the order in which we receive them, this being our final point of connection to all that we have left behind, our tether to the expanding pressures of space and time.

There is no recipe that is only about food. Beef Curry with Chui Jhal is heavy with the weight of generations, warmth of kitchens left long since, and silent adoration of people who nourished us. Whenever we cook this meal, we are in memory and also respecting those who taught us. The beef, slow-cooked until tender, holds stories in every fiber of celebrations, of ordinary Fridays that became extraordinary of hands that stirred with patience we're still learning. Migration can alter our cooking style, though essence remains. With each bite we experience not only spice and meat, but also memory and meaning. The following recipe represents our treasure trove, our legacy, our means of saying that we have not forgotten.

References:

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Recipe Card Template

Recipe name: Beef Curry with Chui Jhal

Place of origin: Khulna, Bangladesh

Variant / style: Festive, traditional homestyle

Associated ritual / occasion: Eid day, wedding, family reunion

Core ingredients:

- Beef
- Chui Jhal
- Mustard oil
- Garlic
- Green chili

Preparation method (high-level):

- Marinate beef with mustard oil, ginger-garlic paste, onion paste, turmeric, green chili, chili powder, and salt. Marinate for 1 hour.
- Heat mustard oil in a pot. Fry sliced onions for 5 minutes. Add spices and marinated beef. Cook for 5 minutes.
- Add water. Cover and simmer. The add Chui Jhal stems when beef is half cooked. Continue cooking until the beef is tender.
- Add some whole garlic cloves 10 minutes before finishing.
- Serve with onions and green chili.

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